

1. Water-Based Styles (Watercolor & Gouache)

Because water-based paints rely heavily on the fluidity of water and the absorbency of paper, styles range from ethereal and transparent to bold and graphic.

- **Wet-on-Wet (Alla Prima / Loose):**
 - *Technique:* Applying wet paint onto pre-wetted paper.
 - *Effect:* Colors bleed and flow into one another organically, creating soft edges, dreamy blooms, and atmospheric skies or loose floral shapes.
- **Wet-on-Dry (Detailed / Precision):**
 - *Technique:* Applying concentrated paint onto dry paper using fine brushes.
 - *Effect:* Crisp edges, high control, and sharp details. Highly popular for botanical illustrations and architectural sketching.
- **Dry Brush:**
 - *Technique:* Using a brush with very little moisture and thick pigment dragged lightly across textured, dry paper.
 - *Effect:* Creates broken, textured lines; ideal for painting rough surfaces like tree bark, hair, sparkling water, or stone.
- **Gouache Flat-Design / Illustration:**
 - *Technique:* Utilizing gouache's matte, opaque nature to lay down solid blocks of flat color.
 - *Effect:* Reminiscent of screen prints or vector art, heavily used in modern children's book illustrations, poster design, and mid-century modern art.
- **Lifting / Subtractive Painting:**
 - *Technique:* Lifting wet or damp paint back off the paper using a clean, damp brush, paper towel, or sponge.
 - *Effect:* Creates highlights, clouds, foam on waves, or soft glowing light sources.

2. Acrylic Styles

Because acrylics can mimic both watercolors (when thinned) and oils (when used thickly), and because they dry fast, they allow for a massive range of styles.

- **Hard-Edge Painting:**
 - *Technique:* Using painter's tape or precise brushwork to lay down flat, geometric planes of pure color with sharp, uncompromising boundaries.
 - *Effect:* Clean, modern, graphic, and clinical (popularized in the 1960s movement by artists like Ellsworth Kelly).
- **Impasto & Textured Acrylic:**
 - *Technique:* Using heavy-body acrylics straight from the tube or mixed with thickening mediums (modeling paste), applied with palette knives or thick brushes.
 - *Effect:* Sculptural, three-dimensional surfaces where ridges and brushstrokes stand proud of the canvas.
- **Glazing & Layering:**

- *Technique:* Applying many ultra-thin, transparent layers of acrylic mixed with a gloss medium over a dried underpainting.
- *Effect:* Rich depth, luminous skin tones, and glowing light effects similar to Renaissance oil painting.
- **Pouring (Fluid Art):**
 - *Technique:* Mixing acrylic paints with a liquid pouring medium and tipping them directly onto the canvas to flow together.
 - *Effect:* Abstract, marble-like cells, organic web patterns, and fluid marble finishes with no brush marks.
- **Staining / Raw Canvas (Color Field):**
 - *Technique:* Watering down fluid acrylics so they soak directly into unprimed cotton canvas, rather than sitting on top.
 - *Effect:* Stained, atmospheric gradients of color that look embedded right into the fabric of the material.

3. Oil Styles

Oil painting's slow drying time makes it the premier medium for smooth transitions, rich layering, and timeless realism.

- **Sfumato (Blended / Smoky):**
 - *Technique:* Meticulously softening transitions between colors and tones so there are no perceptible lines or borders (pioneered by Leonardo da Vinci).
 - *Effect:* A smoky, atmospheric haze; highly prized for lifelike, glowing skin and soft shadows.
- **Alla Prima (Wet-on-Wet Oil):**
 - *Technique:* Completing a painting in a single session while all the layers of oil paint are still completely wet on the canvas.
 - *Effect:* Energetic, spontaneous brushwork with bold, unblended color interactions (popularized by Impressionists and plein-air painters).
- **Chiaroscuro (Dramatic Light & Shadow):**
 - *Technique:* Using strong contrasts between light and dark, usually with a dark, moody background and a single intense light source hitting the subject (mastered by Caravaggio and Rembrandt).
 - *Effect:* High theatrical drama, profound depth, and intense psychological focus.
- **Trompe-l'œil ("Fool the Eye"):**
 - *Technique:* Hyper-realistic oil painting style that uses precise perspective, accurate lighting, and microscopic detail to make two-dimensional objects look three-dimensional.
 - *Effect:* Optical illusions where painted objects look like real items sitting on a surface.
- **Underpainting and Glazing (Flemish Technique):**
 - *Technique:* Painting a detailed monochromatic underpainting (grisaille) to lock in values/shadows, followed by transparent color glazes on top.
 - *Effect:* Exceptional luminosity, depth, and rich jewel-like color saturation.

